DORON

An abstract wooden game for two players

2 players · Ages 8+ · 15 min · Wood



Concept image created with the help of AI. Final design and materials to be defined with the publisher.

One shared piece, one rule, and a lot to think about.

Players take turns moving the red **doron** in a straight line, like a chess queen, and drop one of their stones on the square it has just left. When the doron can no longer move, the game ends: the **largest connected group** wins.

The twist: **you never choose where your own stone lands. Your opponent does**, by choosing where to leave the doron. Every move is a gift to the other player, and a choice of the gifts you leave open for yourself. Hence the name of the red piece: *dōron* is Greek for "gift".

Quick to learn, a game takes about 15 minutes on a 6 × 6 board.

What is new

The placing rule turns the usual race for territory inside out: to build your group, you must make your opponent send the doron where you need it. No luck, no hidden information, nothing to set up.

The decisions

- Grow your group, or block theirs?
- Give a stone away to control what follows?
- Lock the doron now, or play on?
- Who will place the last stone in each pocket?

In the box

- A 6 × 6 beech board with cups
- 22 maple and 22 walnut stones (18 of each for the basic game)
- 1 red doron, the same shape as the stones
- A two-page rules leaflet

Two games in the box, one possible extension

Basic game (6 × 6): the game itself, for families and casual players.

Capture: one extra rule, same board and same box. The stone you place removes a single enemy stone caught between it and one of yours. Livelier games, almost no draws.

Possible extension, 9 × 9 (not in this box): the same rules on a larger board, for players who want a game that rewards study. It could take the form of a reversible board, 9 × 9 on one side and 6 × 6 with a wider frame on the other, and 41 stones of each colour (enough with or without capture).

Tested

Playtests: easy to handle and engaging from the first move to the last; combinations open up from about two-thirds of the game. Children can play as soon as they can picture a territory to build.

Skill pays	more than at Othello or Connect Four: a computer player thinking twice as long scores 75 % (Othello 6 × 6: 66 %, Connect Four: 65 %).
Fair at once	no rule is needed to balance the first move between beginners: the first player scores 49 to 51 %.
Almost no draws	with the capture option, only 2 % of games are drawn (10 % in the basic game).

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Attached: rules (2 p.), tactics guide (4 p.)

Play online: guillaume-enguehard.github.io/games/doron/play

DORON

An abstract game for two players

2 players | Ages 8 and up | About 15 minutes | 6 × 6 board

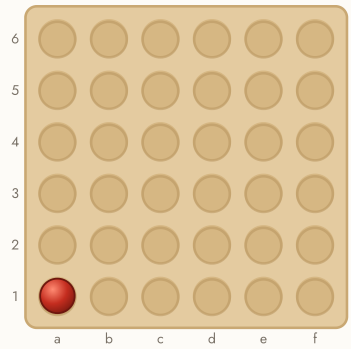
Each turn you move the red doron and drop one of your stones on the square it leaves. **You never choose where your own stone falls: your opponent does.** In return, you decide where your opponent's next stone will fall.

Components

- 1 board of 6 × 6 squares. The corner square **a1**, on Light's left, is the doron's home.
- 18 light stones and 18 dark stones (22 of each for the capture option).
- 1 doron: a red piece, the same shape as the stones. Its name is the Greek word *dōron*, "gift": wherever you leave it, your opponent's next stone will fall.

Aim of the game

Build the **largest group**. A group is a set of stones of one colour linked along their sides. Stones that only touch at a corner are not linked.



1 Start: the doron on its home, a1.

Set-up

The board is empty and the doron stands on its home. Choose colours: **Light plays first.**

Your turn

1. **Move the doron** in a straight line (sideways, forwards, backwards or diagonally) over as many empty squares as you like. It never jumps over a stone and never stops on one.
2. **Place one of your stones on the square it has just left.**

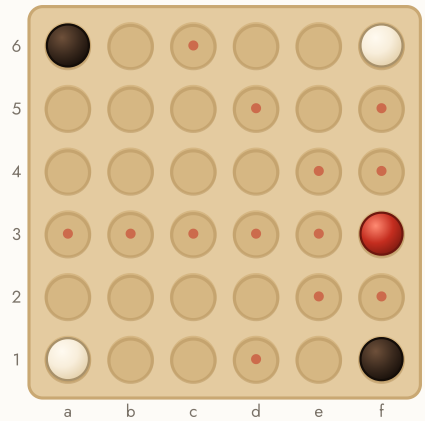
Light's first stone therefore always lands on a1. After that, your stone always lands where your opponent left the doron.

THE KEY IDEA

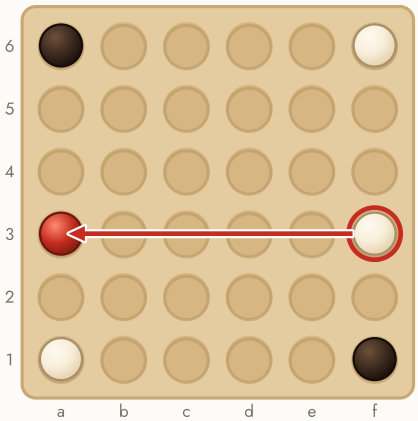
Where you **stop** the doron, your opponent's next stone will fall.

Where your opponent **sends** it, your next stone will fall.

Every move is a double choice: the gift you make, and the gifts you leave open.



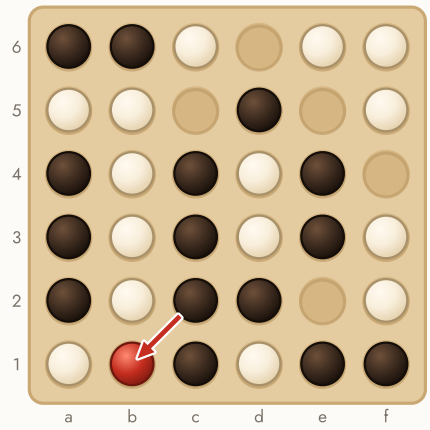
2 **Light to move.** The red dots show every square the doron can reach from f3. The stones on f6 and f1 block the column.



3 Light sends it to **a3** and places a light stone on **f3** (circled). Whatever Dark does next, Dark's stone will land on a3.

End of the game

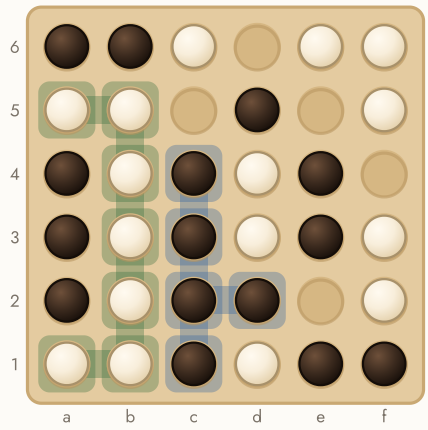
If, at the start of your turn, the doron **cannot move** (all the squares around it are taken), take it off and put one of your stones in its place. The game ends at once. Some squares may stay empty (see figure 4).



4 Dark has just moved the doron from c2 to **b1**. Light cannot move it: Light places a stone on b1 and the game ends.

Who wins?

Each player counts their largest group. **The larger group wins.** If they are the same size, compare the second-largest groups, then the third, and so on. If everything is equal, the game is a draw.



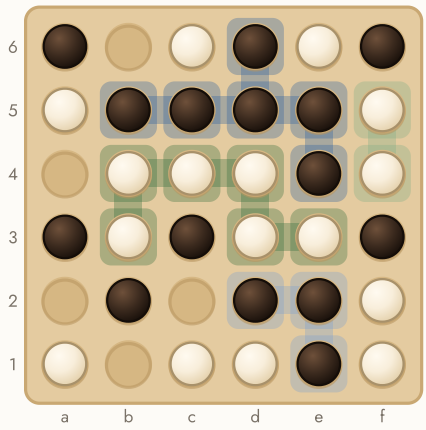
5 The final position. Light's largest group (green) has **7** stones, Dark's (blue) has **5**: **Light wins**.

Playing again?

The loser of the previous game takes Light and plays first.

Names of the squares

Columns a to f, rows 1 to 6; a1 is the doron's home. A game is written as the list of squares the doron is sent to.



6 Another game. Both largest groups have **6** stones. The second groups decide: **3** for Dark against **2** for Light. **Dark wins**.

Club rule (komi)

Between strong players, moving first is a small advantage. To balance it: if both largest groups **and** both second-largest groups are equal, Dark wins.

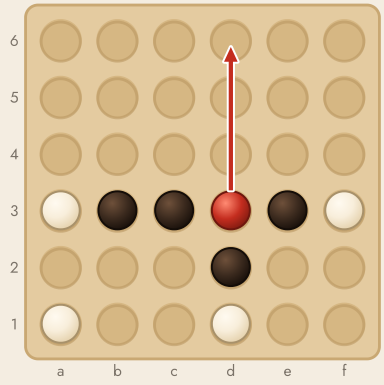
OPTION

Capture

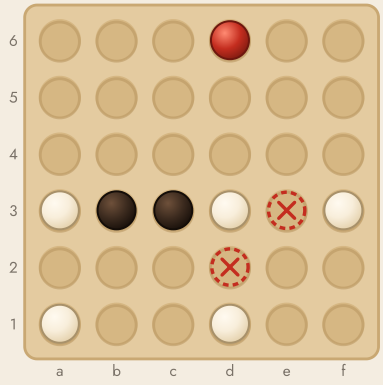
Same game, with one extra rule. After placing your stone, look along the four straight lines from it (up, down, left and right). If **exactly one** opposing stone sits between your new stone and another of your stones, remove it: it goes back to its owner, who can play it again, and the square is empty again, so the doron can pass through it. Each of the four lines is checked: one stone can capture up to four stones at once, one per line.

- Two opposing stones in a row are not captured.
- A capture never triggers another one.
- The doron is neither friend nor foe.
- The last stone, placed where the blocked doron stood, can capture too.
- Very rarely, captures and recaptures repeat the same position. Then stop and count the groups as they stand.

Captures make games livelier (about ten captured stones per game) and draws almost disappear.



7 Light sends the doron from d3 to d6 and places a stone on d3.



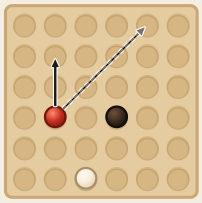
8 d2 (between d3 and d1) and e3 (between d3 and f3) are both removed. b3 and c3 are two in a row: they stay.

DORON

Tactics and strategy, illustrated on the 6 × 6 game

Every position in this guide comes from a real game between computer players and has been **solved exactly to the end**. In each one, the move shown is the **only** winning move, and the tempting move, the one a quick player would choose, loses.

How to read the diagrams



Left diagram: the position. Solid arrow: the winning move. Dashed arrow: the tempting move.

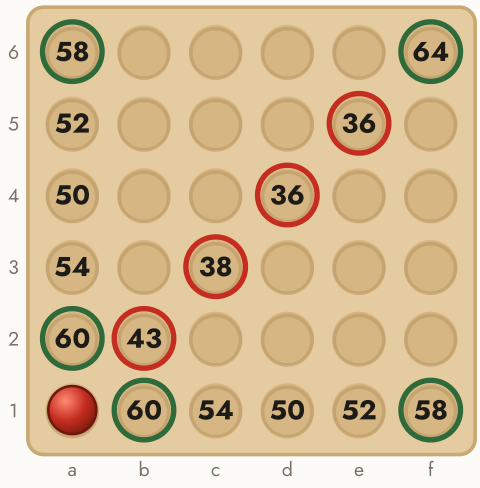


Middle and right: the end of the game after each move, with the best play on both sides. Numbers show the order in which the stones were placed. Green and blue: the largest light and dark groups.

Three questions before every move

1. **Where does my stone fall?** On the square the doron is leaving. You cannot change it, so it is already decided before you move.
2. **What do I give?** The square where I stop the doron receives my opponent's next stone. Does it join one of their groups? Does it link two of them?
3. **What can they give me back?** From that square, my opponent will send the doron along one of its lines, and my next stone will land there. Do those squares touch my groups? Is one of them a dead end?

The seven tactics that follow are answers to these three questions. They come from sorting about 2,500 exactly solved positions in which only one move is best.



The first move. Light's score (%) for each first destination of the doron, from 960 games between strong computer players for each move. Green: best; red: worst.

Strategy 1 · The opening

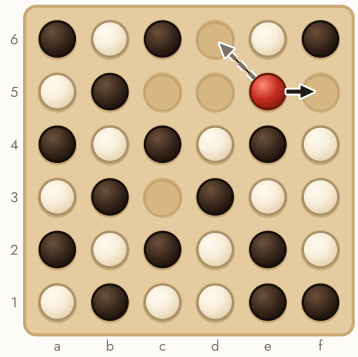
Light's first stone always falls on a1; the real decision is where Dark's first stone will fall.

First move	Light's score
a1 → f6, the opposite corner	64 %
a1 → a2 or b1, along the edge	60 %
a1 → a6 or f1, the other corners	58 %
a1 → b2, c3, d4, e5, the diagonal	36 to 43 %

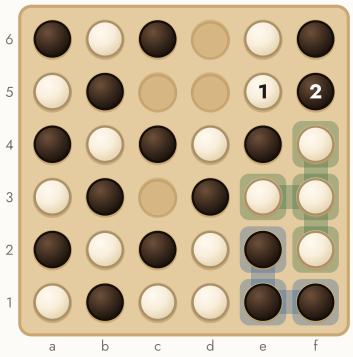
Sending the doron into the centre of the diagonal hands the advantage to Dark: from there, Dark can send it almost anywhere. Corners and edges keep Dark's choices narrow.

TACTIC 1 Lock the doron

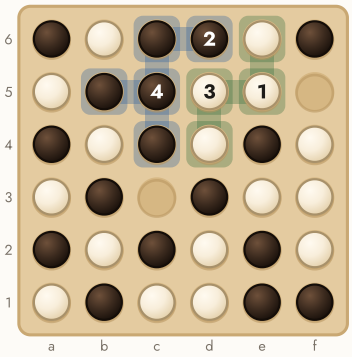
Sending the doron to a square with no way out ends the game: your opponent must take it off and place the last stone in its place. Here Light sends it to **f5**, which is surrounded. Dark's last stone on f5 only joins f6, and the count stops while Light is ahead. Entering the empty pocket instead (d6, d5 or c5) gives Dark the last word there: Dark's stones on d6 and c5 link c6, b5 and c4 into a group of five. *Lock only when the count, as it stands, is yours.*



Light to move. Winning: **f5** (solid). Tempting: **d6** (dashed).



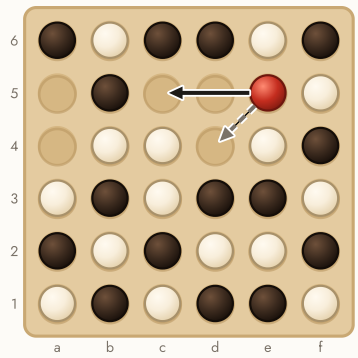
After **f5**: Light **4**, Dark **3**. **Light wins.**



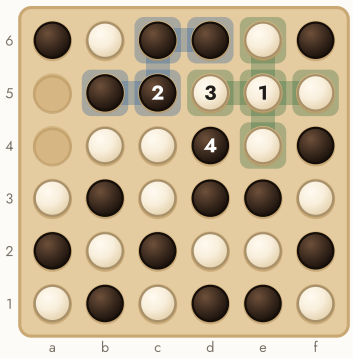
After **d6**: Light **4**, Dark **5**. **Dark wins.**

TACTIC 2 The net

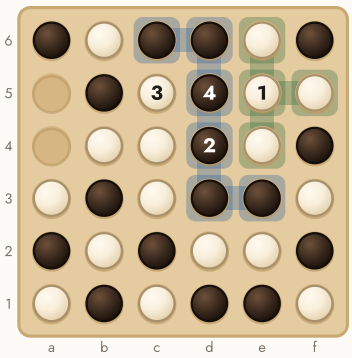
Choose a square from which **every** exit runs into a dead end that suits you. Light is willing to give Dark c5 (Dark's group grows to four) because from c5 the doron has only two exits, d5 and d4, and both are traps: after d5, Light's stone joins its group (5) and the doron is locked on d4; after d4, Light's stone on d4 links eight stones. The natural d4 lets Dark go round through c5 and d5 and finish with six.



Light to move. Winning: **c5** (solid). Tempting: **d4** (dashed).



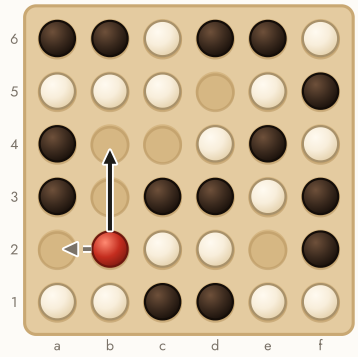
After **c5**: Light **5**, Dark **4**. **Light wins.**



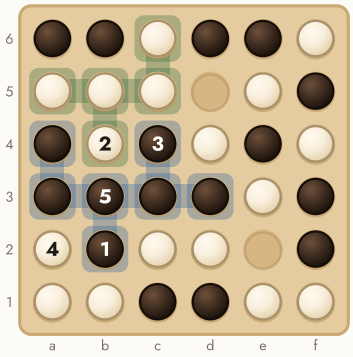
After **d4**: Light **4**, Dark **6**. **Dark wins.**

TACTIC 3 The fork

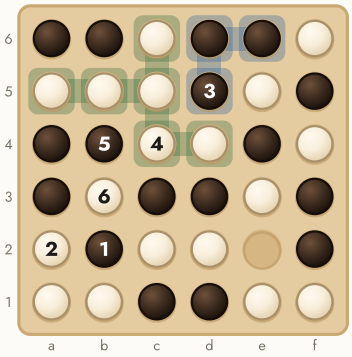
A square where every exit gives you **either** a growing stone **or** a lock. Dark gives Light b4 (Light's group grows to five). From b4, Light can go to b3 or c4. On b3, Dark's stone joins the wall a3–c3–d3 and Dark then locks the doron on a2. On c4, Dark's stone joins the same wall and Dark's last stone on b3 completes a group of seven. The tempting a2 lets Light run the doron across to d5 instead.



Dark to move. Winning: **b4** (solid). Tempting: **a2** (dashed).



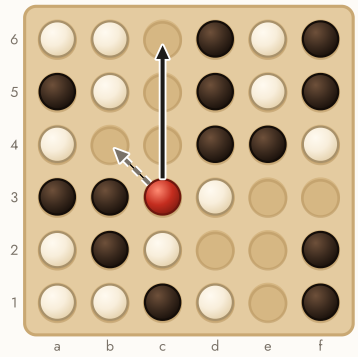
After **b4**: Light **5**, Dark **7**. **Dark wins.**



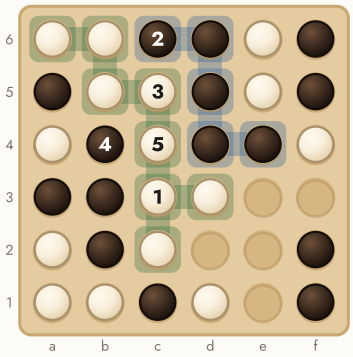
After **a2**: Light **6**, Dark **3**. **Light wins.**

TACTIC 4 Forced junction

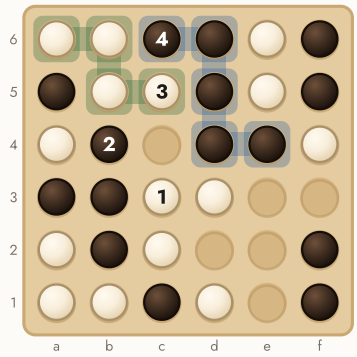
Send the doron where **all** exits touch your own group: whatever your opponent does, your next stone connects. Light gives Dark c6, which joins Dark's group of five. But from c6 the doron can only go down the column, to c5 or c4, and both squares touch light stones. Light's stones then land on c5 and c4 and link the top-left group with c3–d3–c2: **eight** stones. The tempting b4 lets Dark send the doron to c5 at once; the game then ends with the doron locked on c6, c4 stays empty and Light's two groups never meet.



Light to move. Winning: **c6** (solid). Tempting: **b4** (dashed).



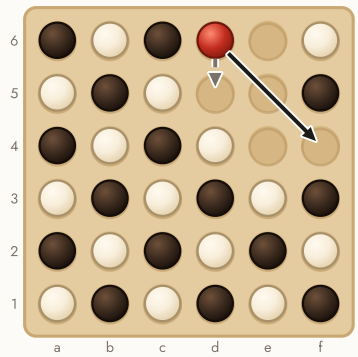
After **c6**: Light **8**, Dark **5**. **Light wins.**



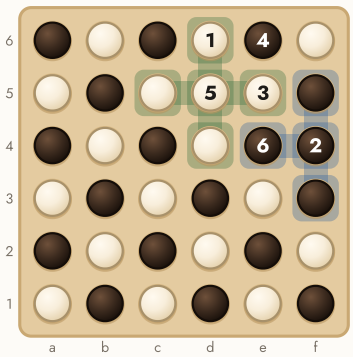
After **b4**: Light **4**, Dark **5**. **Dark wins.**

TACTIC 5 The sacrifice

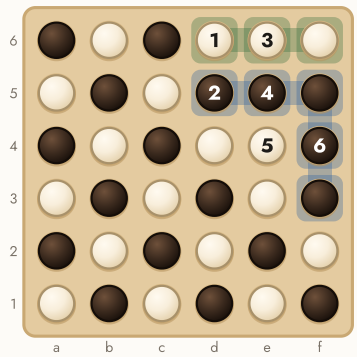
The most frequent winning idea, and the hardest to see: **give your opponent a stone that grows their group**, to control what follows. Every stone here stands alone, except for an empty pocket (d5, e5, e6, e4, f4). Light gives Dark f4, joining f5 and f3 (three stones). In return, the doron must go back into the pocket, and Light's stones fill e5 and d5 to link d6, c5 and d4: Light 5, Dark 4. The quiet-looking d5 gives Dark nothing at first, but Dark's next stones fill d5, e5 and f4 and join f5 and f3: five.



Light to move. Winning: **f4** (solid). Tempting: **d5** (dashed).



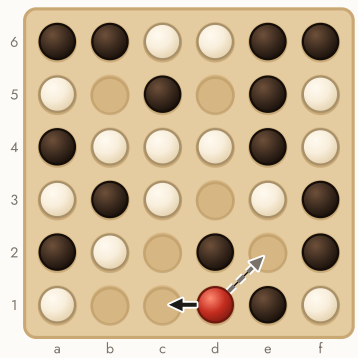
After **f4**: Light **5**, Dark **4**. **Light wins.**



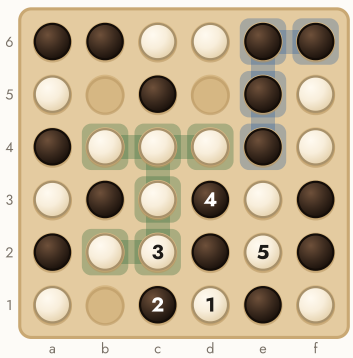
After **d5**: Light **3**, Dark **5**. **Dark wins.**

TACTIC 6 The empty gift

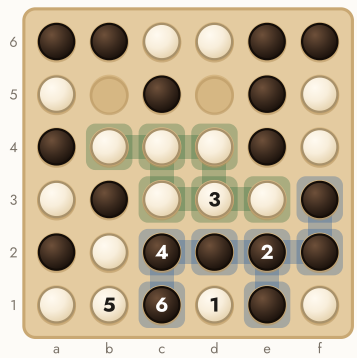
Stop the doron on a square where your opponent's stone will be **useless**, touching none of their stones. Light moves just one square, to c1. Dark's stone will land there, alone; and both of Dark's exits, c2 and b1, touch Light's group, which grows to six. The tempting e2 forces Dark to send the doron to d3, where Light's stone connects at once, but it hands Dark e2, linking four dark stones: Dark finishes with seven.



Light to move. Winning: **c1** (solid). Tempting: **e2** (dashed).



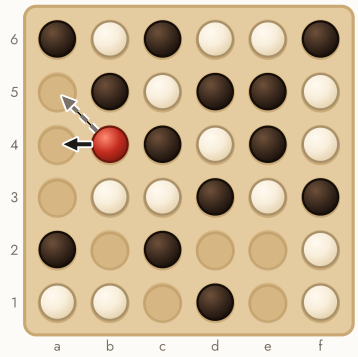
After **c1**: Light **6**, Dark **4**. **Light wins.**



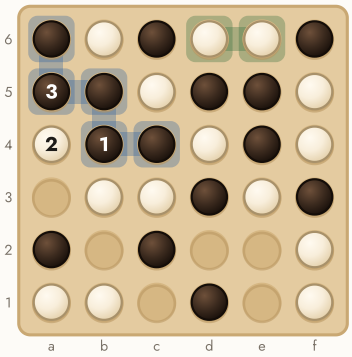
After **e2**: Light **6**, Dark **7**. **Dark wins.**

TACTIC 7 The quiet move

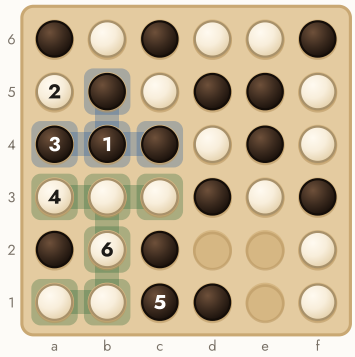
A short move to a square that touches no stone at all can still decide who has the last word. Dark steps into the empty corner, a4. Light must leave by a5 or a3. a5 is a dead end: Dark's last stone lands on a5 and joins a6, b5, b4 and c4 (five). a3 leads to a short race in the bottom-left corner that Dark also wins. The tempting a5 lets Light answer a4; the doron ends up locked on b2, where Light's last stone links six light stones.



Dark to move. Winning: **a4** (solid). Tempting: **a5** (dashed).



After **a4**: Light **2**, Dark **5**. **Dark wins.**



After **a5**: Light **6**, Dark **4**. **Light wins.**

STRATEGY 2 Principles for the whole game

Each principle was measured on about 1,600 positions where the choice matters, then checked on a second set of positions never used to define it. None of them is enough on its own: even the best combination picks an optimal move only 12 points more often than a random choice. Calculation stays indispensable, and that is what keeps every game open.

- **Do not link two of your opponent's groups**, unless you have calculated a sacrifice. In the empty gift above, e2 would have linked four dark stones. *Confirmed in every situation.*
- **Send the doron towards your own groups.** The more of its exits touch your stones, the more likely your next stone connects (the forced junction). *The strongest principle, confirmed in every situation.*
- **When you are ahead, give empty squares** that touch none of your opponent's stones (the empty gift). *Confirmed when ahead; useless when behind.*
- **When you are level or behind, smother:** give the square that blocks your opponent's growth, even if it adds a stone to their group (the sacrifice). *Helps when level or behind, not when ahead.*
- **Lock the doron only when the count, as it stands, is yours** (the closure). Locking just because you are ahead brings nothing.
- **Do not trust simple counting.** Counting the empty squares to guess who will place the last stone gains nothing as a rule of thumb: in a pocket, the last word has to be read out move by move (the net, the quiet move).